

AI Ethics and Hate Speech

By Maha Jouini, Founder, African Center for Artificial Intelligence and Digital Technology

This module explores the intersection between AI and hate speech in the context of the MENA region. Maha Jouini discusses how algorithms have exacerbated the challenge of hate speech, highlighting the role of social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter in further spreading harmful content. She goes on to explain the far reaching consequences of hate speech in the region, drawing on her years of work as an activist. The module concludes with an overview of potential solutions to the challenge, which offer lessons for actors engaged in building ethical AI systems across the world.

Lecture Transcript

00:00 Good Afternoon, Hello, Salaam-Alaikum. I am Maha Jouini, the founder of African Center for Artificial Intelligence and Digital Technology. I'm based in Mauritania. And I'm really honored and humbled to be invited as a lecturer with AI Ethics initiative. I would love to welcome all of you for attending the course about AI ethics and hate speech, where I'm going to focus on hate speech in MENA region.

00:48 In my presentation, I will start with a welcome message, a short presentation about African Center for Artificial Intelligence and Digital Technology, plus the concept of MENA region, because I guess that most of you may not be familiar with it. Third part will be about hate speech and artificial intelligence. Then the spread of hate speech and its impact in the MENA region. Fifth part is about problems. Then we will go to analyze the solutions, what we can do against hate speech. Then next steps, and we end up by references, which I believe it would be useful for you.

01:42 First of all, I would love to introduce myself. I'm Maha Jouini, author and founder of African Center for Artificial Intelligence and Digital Technology. I'm a PhD candidate in the field of computer science and data science. I hold a Master's from Tianjin University of Education and Technology in China. I published several articles about artificial intelligence, the future of work in Africa, and women's inclusion. Moreover, I worked at the African Union campaign to end child marriage in Africa between 2015 and 2017. I've published two books. The first book, titled *Lover from Africa*, where I spotlight the situation of women who come from minority groups in North Africa. The second book, titled *The Last Dance from Carthage to China*, where I wrote my journey - how I was a student in China and how Asians perceive Africans.

02:55 Well, last year, my friends and I, we launched the African Center for AI and Digital Technology called the AICAIT. It's a Pan African Think Tank, interested in supporting AI policies in the African continent, and conducting research on digital transformation impact and its challenges in the continents. We, in AICAIT, we believe in Agenda 2063 aspirations and we are working to make digital technology and artificial intelligence accessible to all African citizens and MENA region's people.

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03:36 Well, here is the MENA region. The MENA region, it's an acronym of North Africa and Middle East. Well, the connection between all these countries, I think, all of us, we speak Arabic. All of us we have kind of common history, especially the language aspects. Plus religion. We are most of us, we are all Muslims, with minorities of Christians, Jews, Bahá'is, some other, Druze, Mhallamis, some other communities, Coptics too. Well, our center is providing AI policy studies in Arabic to spread the knowledge in North Africa in a way to enable youth understanding the terminology of artificial intelligence concepts and artificial intelligence ethics, because we think that it's easier for them to understand when the knowledge is presented in their own language, in Arabic. In addition to this, there are fact that the speakers of foreign languages, the youth who are able to speak and understand in English or in French, most of them are among the region's elites and have studied in foreign universities and institutes. So to make sure that the knowledge is well spread, we choose to publish, and to raise the debate about AI in Arabic.

05:37 Let me introduce you to hate speech. United Nations defines hate speech as: "hate speech can be conveyed through any form of expression, including images, cartoons, memes, objects, gestures and symbols, and it can be disseminated offline or online". Hate speech is discriminatory - biased, bigoted, intolerant - or "pejorative", in other words prejudiced, contemptuous or demeaning, of an individual or group. However, in MENA region, we don't have any official governmental definition of hate speech. As a result, there are no sentences or penalties to those who post or share any violence speech. I hope the idea is clear now.

06:44 Well, I would love to share with you this screenshot of a caricature. This, the evil, he's putting on his head the ISIS, and he's killing, he's putting on a funeral, the diligence of Islam. So, like, the peaceful people are dying, and the one who's controlling, who are talking on behalf of the religion and are doing the hate speech, they are the fanatic group, the ISIS. Well, why did I? Why do I take you to the religious part? Because in MENA region hate speech, the source of hate speech - it comes from the fanatic, the fundamentalis, groups. I hope my idea is clear.

07:45 Also, the victims of hate speeches are always belonging to minority groups, such as LGBT, women, religious minority groups, especially Christians and Jews, and Blacks, as they are called as "slaves". We, in Arabic, we say "abeed". So in MENA region, for most of the case, when they want to like, when they want to humiliate someone, if he has dark skin, they will call him "abeed", "eabd" or "abn aleabd". This word means "child of slave", "slave" and so on. Well, I'm sharing with you one of the victims of hate speech. This caricature comes from Sudan. You see here, an old man. He goes, he goes to a lady. She's walking in the streets simply and he starts to blaming her and giving her his remarks to her, saying in Arabic (*reading in Arabic*), which means, "You, girl, cover your head. Don't forget that we are practicing Islamist law in this country". This attitude of blaming women and getting into women's business, this is the result of hate speech spread by fundamentalists, where the first victim of it are women.

09:42 Like me, for example. This case happens to me the last weekend. I'm here in a workshop, and there's a woman passing across to me. She stopped her car and she asked me to cover my hair and she insulted me. And I was really shocked because I'm in the middle of the street and she came and she did this for me. Why she did that? Because there are full of hate speech against the woman, the Muslim woman who don't cover their hair like I do. And we end up by being victims of violating our rights on the street. And people, they say to us harmful words, because we don't wear in the way in which they want us to wear.

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10:38 Well, the spread of hate speech in the Arab region throughout social media. There are a sharp, a sharp increase in online hate speeches have raised concerns globally and especially in MENA, since the rise of the Arab Spring 2011, which accorded with the high demands to liberate cyberspace and expression rights. Over time, in the case of Tunisia and Libya, religious parties, and armed militias benefited from the transformation in social networking pages commonly, commonly Facebook. Facebook has somehow changed into incubator of hateful and condescending rhetoric in order to implement religious law and call for religious dress for women. Also, there are calls for polygamy, killing the infidels. The infidels, this terminology in Islam religion means those who refuse to apply the Muslim law, such as covering the hair, covering the head. So for some fundamentalist groups, me, I'm considered as infidel. Is it clear?

12:16 Plus, there are calls to fight against the non-Arab minority groups in the region. Non-Arab minority groups, we talk about the Black, the Kurds in MENA region, the Imazighn indigenous community of North Africa, the Behá'is. Each minority, each culture, which their own people refuse to admit to the fundamentalist laws.

12:56 There are also an impact of hate speech in civil peace and coexistence among people. First of all, I would like to remind you that the minority of Tutsi in Rwanda. Do you remember the genocide in Rwanda where the Tutsi minority were killed? You know why? Because at that time, the majority were calling the Tutsi as “cockroaches” and they were killed and they were dehumanizing them. By the time Tutsi became the victims of genocide. Before the genocide started, the Tutsi minority were killed by inhuman words.

14:06 In June 2011, the Syrian president, Bashar al-Assad, uses the same words which were used before against the Tutsi minority. He used it to describe the peaceful protestors in the country. Later, these terminologies were used by the Syrian regime, in its media, its supporters, such as “intruders” and “saboteurs”. And these words appeared in an attempt to exclude the revolutionaries and negate their patriotism. So hate speech also, when used by some leaders, some political leaders. You know, even our president, Kaïs Saïed, he used the same words to criticize the leftist parties, the leftist political parties who stood up against his coup d'état last year. So the president of my government, I'm Tunisian, so our president, in his speech, he described all the democratic activists in words which deny their patriotism and deny their rights, saying as they are not faithful to Tunisia, they don't love the country, they are not even faithful to Islam. He used all kind of hate speech against his opponents. Well in case of Libya, military groups are using internet and social media platforms to launch campaigns and cyber violence against all Libyan human rights defenders, authors, thinkers, and so on, because they were demanding to silence the guns and they called for a civil state.

16:59 Hate speech in cyberspace turns into religious extremism and calls to join extremist religious groups. I captured some tweets from Twitter. For example, this tweet says that “USA and Europe lead by The Evil are launching a war to eradicate Islam from the earth through pushing you people to support LGBT groups and giving freedoms to women”. And these tweets were well spreaded. There are other tweets. This comes from a channel, in a Farsi word, Kalemeh al-Farisi. This says that a Friday Imam - an imam is the religious leader, the person who leads the prayer for Muslims each Friday. Well, so a Friday Imam in Tehran calls for the celebration of the Aleppo massacre, and he considers it as similar to the victory of the Prophet Muhammad over his enemy 15 centuries ago. Can you believe it? Can you believe it? That people, innocents, children, women were killed by the regime of

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al-Assad years ago and there are an iman, a religious leader, celebrating this massacre as a victory of the Prophet Muhammad against his enemy? Yes. No comments.

18:55 Well, there are two major problems I'd love to figure out. First of all, the algorithm AI become part of promoting hate speech in the region. Algorithm did not control hate speech, such as islamophobia, hate of Jews and racism. Main social media platforms, such as Facebook and Twitter, have made great efforts to combat the spread of hate speech in their platform. Granted, Facebook removed millions of posts featuring hate speech on its platform in 2020. However, there is a long way to go, especially for languages other than English, because hate speech, gender-based violence, all kinds of racism still exist if it is written in different languages, such as Arabic or any other local languages.

19:55 I wrote these three sentences in Arabic. This is my experience. The three sentences: (1) fight the infidels; (2) enemies of Islam; (3) Islam is in danger. As a result, I was stopped by pictures, messages full of violence, and many groups were calling for combatting feminists, progressive thinkers like I and anyone who opposes the religious parties, as well as pictures of Arab woman from the non Muslim and Sunni ethnic and racial minorities. I can adopt that the hate speech is growing, and there are serious threats to the lives of supporters of democracy and freedom in the Arab region. Like in figure 2, it is a group in Facebook asking, asking Muslim Arabs to join and come together to fight and do war against Islam's enemies who are being called as "kuffar" in Arabic. Like if these you know, nowadays, the fundamentalist group consider each person who opposes, refuse to admit the fundamentalist law as "kuffar" means infidel or unbelievable of God.

21:27 So me, for example, I was being considered as "kuffara" in 2014. I received a lot of threats because like I wrote many articles against fundamentalist groups. At that time, I had a blog in France24. So as a result of my articles, my blogs for democracy, for women's freedom, and so on, I received these online threats. Like, yes, this is the this is the screenshot of the group called "Fighting against the Non-Muslim community". Yes, well, how can we stop hate speech from the internet? Let's see. Experience of Facebook and Twitter. Facebook now employs 40,000 people responsible for safety and security and has invested 13 billions for this purpose since 2016. Twitter, hate speech, Twitter's hate speech policy was recently updated and states that "users should not promote violence against, attack or threaten others directly because of their race, ethnic or national origin". Yet accounts that engage in these practices remain active on the platform.

23:00 Again, there are lots of accounts, Twitter accounts, full of hate speech and gender based violence remain active on Twitter platform such as the account of Yusuf al-Qaradawi. You can see it is one in the MENA region. The account of Abdulaziz Al-Tarefe is always calling for war against the infidel of Islam and his screen, this screen, I did it in July 11. And he said "*(reading in Arabic)*". If I want to translate it, he's asking Muslim people to not believe those sermon, because according to him, that US and Europe, they are the enemies, the first enemy of Islam. Okay? So he's calling the MENA region's people, the Muslim people, to don't trust the Europeans and American as long as they are Christians and they are Jews, while we do have our own Christian. We do have Coptics, we do have Tunisian Jews. So why would you have to get into this religious war? While we are living in 2022, people are living peacefully.

25:04 Well, this capture is from Hizb-Ut-Tahrir. This is a fundamentalist, Muslim political party.

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They have already an account in Twitter. And those people are calling for child marriage. They consider that the Tunisian constitution - it's not their constitution. They want to apply the Sharia law. And they promote the idea of separating women and men. They think that women, they should be at home, they don't have to work. They call for polygamy. They call to eradicate and stop civic engagement, so like they even like the civic state itself, they do not admit it. They don't accept it. So this political party, and they are well spread on the internet. However, however, they don't have even any authorization from the government, because they don't believe in civic state, they don't believe in the constitution. And though they have videos, all their ideas is widespread on Twitter and Facebook. You can find it in Google. This is simple. It shows the limits of Twitter, Facebook policies in eradicating hate speech.

26:44 Well, limitation of Meta company and Twitter solutions against hate speech. Apart of limit languages mentioned below, there are a lot of fanatic Muslim leaders and thinkers hostile to women's rights, and the clerics from the Sunni and Shiite religious sects have accounts on social media platforms through which they publish their ideas, such as: the exiled Egyptian cleric Yusuf al-Qaradawi and Qais al-Khazali. I think I showed for you the screenshot of his, al-Qaradawi. They are designated as terrorists. Their accounts remain active and prominent. Yusuf al-Qaradawi has 3.2 million followers. Qais al-Khazali, also, both were the subjects of Arab News' Deep Dive series. Al-Qaradawi wrote one day, "throughout history, God subjected them, he means the Jews, to people who punished them for their corruption. The last punishment was meted out to them by Hitler. It was a punishment from God. Next time, God willing, the faithful believers will punish them." So Yusuf al-Qaradawi considers that what Hitler did, the Nazi movement, the inhuman Nazis movement, it was a God's punishment to the Jews. Mhmm.

28:24 I suggest automatic detection of hate speech, promotion of AI ethics from MENA region perspective, because all solutions for peace building values and AI ethics are generally initiated by experts who are outside from the region. Plus popularizing and promotion of AI ethics values among the whole population, because in the mentioned before Arab countries, studying technology and engaging in civic and cultural work are considered as elite activities and is a kind of privilege for some classes. According to the Observatory of the Arab League Educational, Cultural and Scientific Organization (ALECSO), the rate of illiteracy are in: Iraq, 20%; Tunisia, 18%; Syria, 14%. If you look at these countries—Iraq, Tunisia and Syria—these countries are full of hate speech. There are a lot of terrorist attacks, a lot of problems living together, and lack of democracy.

29:51 Another study published by the Economic and Social Forum in Tunisia, it says that most of the young people who were involved in terrorist operations and who went to Iraq and Syria have not completed their university education, and most of them, they are coming from neighborhoods, of the capital, Tunis. So they don't come from the upper class, in general they come from the poor cities. Plus introducing AI ethics to all stakeholders with their own language. As long as foreign languages is a privilege, we have to provide knowledge, curriculums, reports, studies in Arabic language and reach the local community. Course training, because course trainings are in general delivered in English or in French, and as you know, it's always being presented by international experts. So to make it more real, to make it more applicable, youth in MENA, in North Africa especially, they have to get those trainings in their own language by their own people, cause it's their own issue first of all.

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31:20 MENA region's community needs to feel that AI ethics is human and global values. And they have to believe, also, that they are part of the international movement of promoting AI ethics. They have to feel valued. They have to feel respected. And we need to engage them, not only to transfer the knowledge for them, no. They have to be part of a solution, they have to feel it. And that's why, I said, we need a MENA region approach, because in general, looks like we people are just receiving the knowledge, we don't create it. And to end terrorism, to end hate speech, we have to be part of the solution. Building an anti-hate discourse by "creating a space for open discussion and dialogue that allow us to build an understanding of each other and realize the value of what we have in common". Listening, questioning and constructive participation, by avoiding offensive and direct confrontation with adherents of hate speech, because it may push them to prove, and to consist in, their own opinions.

32:51 Well, I'm sharing with you a photo of Salwa Bugaighis. She's a Libyan lawyer, were killed in her own house in 2014 as a result of hate speech and campaign were led by Libyan militias against her. So she was killed as a result of online hate speech. It's awful to her, I mean.

33:35 Reference material. Improvement of framework for hate speech using machine learning. Adversarial generative-based data augmentation. And this is a link of a journal of Sage Pub. And if you need more information, you can reach me on my email. Also my LinkedIn. I'm Maha Jouini from African Center for AI and Digital Technology. Would love to hear from you.